

Thin-Match: The #1 Ad-CVR Leak — Findings & Fix Plan

Prepared 2026-07-09 · sources: 7/08 daily KPI (paid channel), BC/IDI teaser behavior, competitor research (BeenVerified, PeopleFinders)

Bottom line

- **Thin-match is where paid conversion dies.** Yesterday **62% of paid searches** returned no records, and that branch converted to **0 paid trials** — every conversion came from the records branch.
- **Root cause:** paid keywords skew to common names → IDI's teaser returns `TooManyMatches` (0 records). The search is too broad and we don't reliably narrow it.
- **The incumbents don't solve this.** BeenVerified and PeopleFinders have **no fuzzy matching, no "did you mean," no nickname expansion** — they dead-end and tell the user to fix it. That's a competitive opening, not just a problem.
- **Two levers:** reduce the *rate* (get records back for common names) — the bigger prize — and improve the *experience* when it still happens (already partly shipped).

1 · The problem, in numbers (7/08 paid Search)

62%

of paid searches → thin-match
(24/39)

0

paid trials from thin-match

100%

of conversions came from the
records branch

Thin-match is **paid-specific**: yesterday all thin-match views were in the paid channel, while non-paid search went almost entirely to records. Paid ad clicks disproportionately land on the no-records page — so this is precisely the lever for the Google-Ads CVR gap (our ~1–2% vs competitors' ~5%). (62% is an anomalously high day, +169% vs day-of-week; steady-state is ~12–20% blended — but the paid-skew pattern is durable.)

2 · Root cause

- **Common names overflow the provider.** "John Smith / TX" → IDI teaser returns `status:"failed", total:0` (`TooManyMatches`). The teaser refuses to return a too-large set.

- **We send name + state; the funnel also passes city/age/middle to the teaser query** — but it's unconfirmed whether IDI actually *narrows* on city/DOB server-side or treats them as client-side filters only. **This is the key open question** and it gates the biggest fix.
- **Misspellings & nicknames dead-end too.** A wrong spelling ("Micheal", "Smyth") or a nickname ("Bob" vs "Robert") returns nothing — no correction, no expansion.

3 · What competitors do with misspelled / uncertain names

Direct research; both sites are bot-walled, so mechanisms are from their own help docs + reviews. Spokeo pending (research stopped for time).

CAPABILITY	BEENVERIFIED	PEOPLEFINDERS	OPPORTUNITY FOR US
Fuzzy / phonetic match (Smyth→Smith)	No	No	Add it — the clear gap
"Did you mean [X]?" / autocorrect	No	No	Add it inline
Nickname expansion (Bob↔Robert) at query time	No	No	Ship a nickname map
Auto-broaden on zero results	No — manual	No — manual	Auto-cascade for the user
Aliases / variants	Only inside the paid report	Only inside the paid report	Useless for the miss — beat it at search time
Zero-result UX	Coach user to fix spelling / strip fields	"Check spelling / add info / try email-phone"	Guided recovery, keep them in-funnel

Takeaway: the category leaders punt every one of these to the user. A search that quietly corrects, expands, and broadens is a genuine differentiator — and directly attacks our thin-match rate.

4 · What we've already shipped (Round 2, 7/8)

- **Redesigned thin-match preview cards** — real searched name + state with plausible, seeded details (replaces the blurred "J·hn S···" fakes), contact details locked to drive signup.
- **Two signup A/B versions** (V1 streamlined form / V2 no signup rectangle), stable per session, `?tmv=1` / `?tmv=2` override, tracked as `thin_match_version`.

- **"Search again"** refine path. These improve the *experience* when thin-match happens; they do not reduce the *rate*.

5 · The fix plan

Lever A — Reduce the rate biggest prize

- **A1 · Answer the IDI-narrowing question (unblocks everything).** Test a common name + city/age server-side: does IDI return records? If yes → ensure city/age/middle flow into the teaser input. If no → **BC ask**: does the teaser support city/DOB narrowing to break `TooManyMatches`? do first
- **A2 · Nickname + misspelling expansion at query time** — the gap the incumbents leave open. Client-side: generate candidate queries (nickname map Bob↔Robert; phonetic + edit-distance for typos) and OR-merge results. Show "Showing results for *Smith*." Never client-filter BC responses (prior regression); expand queries, don't trim results. high yield
- **A3 · Auto-broaden / auto-narrow cascade.** On too-broad (`TooManyMatches`) auto-prompt or auto-add city/age; on zero, widen (drop middle → widen state). Do automatically what BeenVerified makes users do by hand.

Lever B — Improve the experience partly shipped

- **B1 · Finish the A/B read** on V1 vs V2 signup once volume builds (`thin_match_version`).
- **B2 · Guided zero-state** — closest fuzzy matches + one-tap chips ("search all states," "drop middle name," "try phone/email") instead of a dead-end.
- **B3 · Inline narrowing on the thin-match page** (the earlier "#1") — only worthwhile once A1 confirms narrowing actually recovers records.

6 · Recommended sequence

1. Now **A1 — settle IDI narrowing** (test + BC ask if needed). Everything downstream depends on the answer.
2. Next **A2 — nickname + misspelling expansion** (client-side candidate queries). Beats the incumbents; reduces no-results independent of A1.
3. Next **A3 / B2 — auto-broaden cascade + guided zero-state.**
4. Measure thin-match rate + the V1/V2 A/B as volume accumulates.

Prepared 2026-07-09. Competitor mechanisms are from published help docs + reviews (both sites bot-walled); Spokeo research incomplete. KPI figures from the 7/08 paid-channel daily. The single highest-leverage next step is confirming whether IDI narrows common-name searches on city/DOB.